

Session 11: The Hebrew Bible as a Mosaic

Key Takeaways

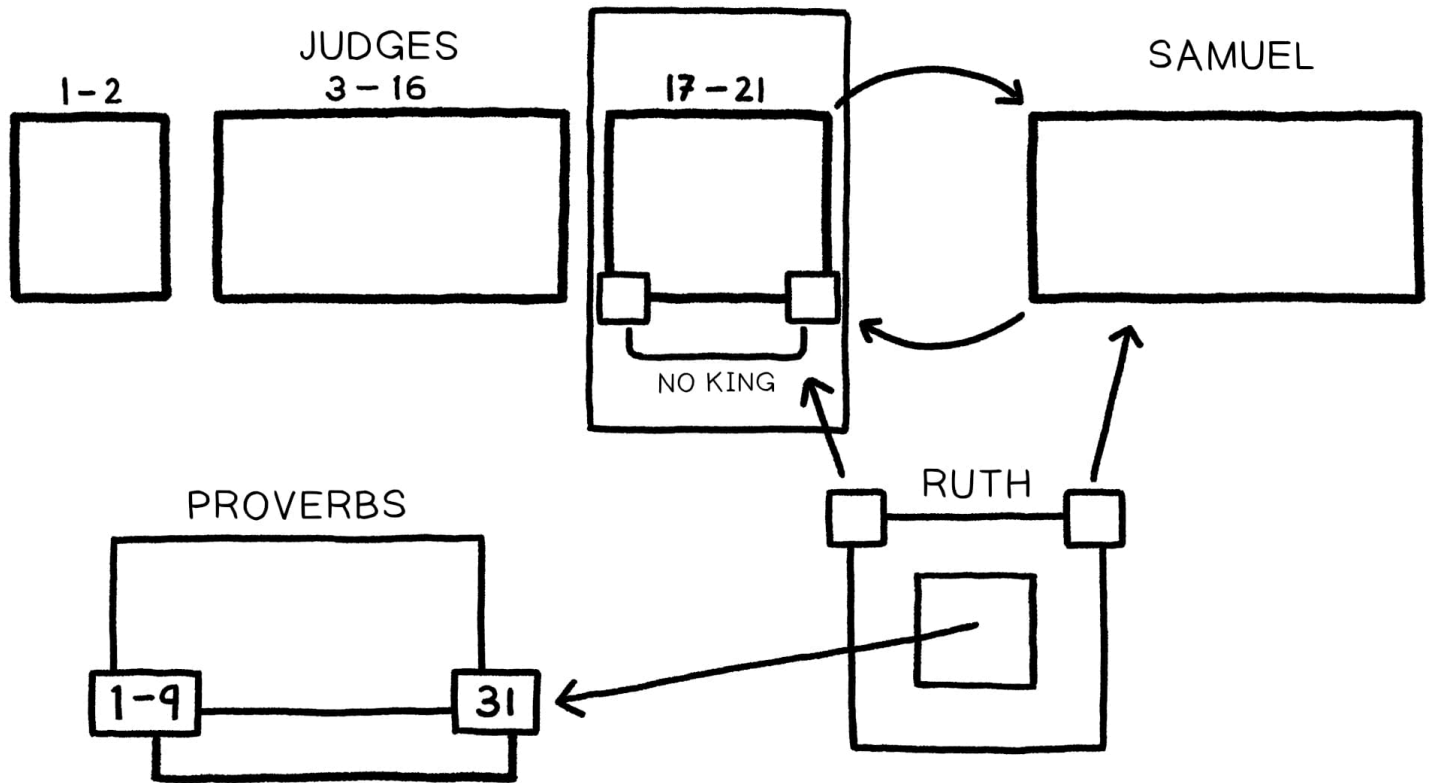
- The Hebrew Bible is a collection of scrolls that has been arranged with a mosaic (i.e., composite) unity.
- The Ketuvim (i.e., the Writings) acts as mini-commentaries on the themes and ideas at work elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible.
- The Hebrew Bible can be likened to a family quilt made up of individual pieces from various people throughout different time periods. And each individual piece adds new layers of meaning and significance when viewed within the context of the piece as a whole.

How the Hebrew Bible is Like a Family Quilt

A quilt is made of many preexisting materials and consists of individual pieces (like Ruth or Esther) or sub-collections (the laws at Mount Sinai, Psalms). These earlier materials can be incorporated as they stand or editorially reshaped to fit the new context. But the new overall context of the final quilt gives each individual piece a new layer of meaning when viewed within a larger context and frame of reference.



The first line of Ruth hyperlinks the story to the time of Judges, and its final section is a genealogy that leads to David. The ordering of modern Christian Bibles reflects this by placing Ruth chronologically between the time of the book of Judges and the book of Samuel. The book of Ruth also reflects key language that hyperlinks the character of Ruth to Lady Wisdom from the book of Proverbs. The ordering of the TaNaK places Ruth thematically after the book of Proverbs, where Ruth serves as an expanded commentary on [Proverbs 31](#).



Ruth's Position in the Bible. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Reflection Question

You've seen how the book of Ruth is hyperlinked to Judges, Samuel, and Proverbs. This happens all throughout the Hebrew Bible! Do you think that seeing these hyperlinks is necessary for understanding the meaning of a text or book? Explain your reasoning.